The Choices of Pregnancy and Motherhood Collection

By Anne Sexton and Audre Lorde

INTRODUCTION

"You're pregnant . . . but you have a number of options." Options . . . What a perplexing word. Abortion, Adoption . . . Keep the Baby. The options . . . . sounds so simple . . . . just make a choice.

We live in a society that ignores the painful consequences of abortion. As one woman said: "We were convinced that the abortion was the best thing rather than the right thing." Men and women who have experienced it are urged into denial, so they do not talk about and process the normal feelings of anxiety, fear, shame, guilt and grief which often follow the abortion. When such emotions are denied and buried, they will often resurface having been magnified by time. Anne Sexton focus on the emotional ramifications of The Abortion.

The Abortion by Anne Sexton

Somebody who should have been born

is gone.

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Just as the earth puckered its mouth,

each bud puffing out from its knot,

I changed my shoes, and then drove south.

Up past the Blue Mountains, where

Pennsylvania humps on endlessly,

wearing, like a crayoned cat, its green hair,

its roads sunken in like a gray washboard;

where, in truth, the ground cracks evilly,

a dark socket from which the coal has poured,

Somebody who should have been born

is gone.

the grass as bristly and stout as chives,

and me wondering when the ground would break,

and me wondering how anything fragile survives;

up in Pennsylvania, I met a little man,

not Rumpelstiltskin, at all, at all...

he took the fullness that love began.

Returning north, even the sky grew thin
like a high window looking nowhere.
The road was as flat as a sheet of tin.

Somebody who should have been born
is gone.

Yes, woman, such logic will lead
to loss without death. Or say what you meant,
you coward...this baby that I bleed.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Anne Sexton
Book: All My Pretty Ones
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TRANSITION

Many of us have seen glimpses of mothers who have recently surrendered their baby for adoption. Sometimes the mother is euphoric over the birth of her beautiful son or daughter and tries to focus on that joyous event and "be brave". She may say at least she managed to save her baby from abortion. She may do her best to go on with her life, believing that she will soon get over it and go on with her life. Sometimes the mother has a complete breakdown or turns to drinking or drugs to try to ease her suffering over this tremendous loss. Just remember the privilege of having the Option if you are an Unknown Girl in the maternity Ward by Anne Sexton.

Unknown Girl in the Maternity Ward by Anne Sexton

Child, the current of your breath is six days long.
You lie, a small knuckle on my white bed;
lie, fisted like a snail, so small and strong
at my breast. Your lips are animals; you are fed
with love. At first hunger is not wrong.
The nurses nod their caps; you are shepherded
down starch halls with the other unnested throng
in wheeling baskets. You tip like a cup; your head
moving to my touch. You sense the way we belong.

But this is an institution bed.
You will not know me very long.

The doctors are enamel. They want to know
the facts. They guess about the man who left me,
some pendulum soul, going the way men go
and leave you full of child. But our case history
stays blank. All I did was let you grow.
Now we are here for all the ward to see.
They thought I was strange, although
I never spoke a word. I burst empty
of you, letting you learn how the air is so.
The doctors chart the riddle they ask of me
and I turn my head away. I do not know.

Yours is the only face I recognize.
Bone at my bone, you drink my answers in.
Six times a day I prize
your need, the animals of your lips, your skin
growing warm and plump. I see your eyes
lifting their tents. They are blue stones, they begin

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to outgrow their moss. You blink in surprise
and I wonder what you can see, my funny kin,
as you trouble my silence. I am a shelter of lies.
Should I learn to speak again, or hopeless in
such sanity will I touch some face I recognize?

Down the hall the baskets start back. My arms
fit you like a sleeve, they hold
catkins of your willows, the wild bee farms
of your nerves, each muscle and fold
of your first days. Your old man's face disarms
the nurses. But the doctors return to scold
me. I speak. It is you my silence harms.
I should have known; I should have told
them something to write down. My voice alarms
my throat. "Name of father—none." I hold
you and name you bastard in my arms.

And now that's that. There is nothing more
that I can say or lose.
Others have traded life before

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and could not speak. I tighten to refuse

your owling eyes, my fragile visitor.

I touch your cheeks, like flowers. You bruise

against me. We unlearn. I am a shore

rocking you off. You break from me. I choose

your only way, my small inheritor

and hand you off, trembling the selves we lose.

Go child, who is my sin and nothing more.

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Anne Sexton
Book: Poetry Out Loud: The Anthology
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Date (Month/Year):

AWARD HISTORY

2008 National Qualifier

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TRANSITION

Parenting (the OTHER OPTION) can be one of life's most joyous experiences. And can bring with it many rewards: the warmth of cuddling with a baby; proudly watching as a toddler takes a first step, or tearfully putting your little one on a school bus for the first time! However, parenting can also be the hardest, most demanding job you'll ever undertake. It means being responsible for the care and nurture of a child for at least 18 years. It requires dedication, patience, and sacrifice. Sounded so easy at the beginning didn't it. "You're pregnant . . . but you have options – Options that will affect you for the rest of your life. New that I am Forever with Child by Audre Lorde.

Now that I am Forever with Child by Audre Lorde

How the days went

while you were blooming within me

I remember each upon each---

the swelling changed planes of my body

and how you first fluttered, then jumped

and I thought it was my heart.

How the days wound down

and the turning of winter

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I recall, with you growing heavy

against the wind. I thought

now her hands

are formed, and her hair

has started to curl

now her teeth are done

now she sneezes.

Then the seed opened

I bore you one morning just before spring

My head rang like a fiery piston

my legs were towers between which

A new world was passing

Since then

I can only distinguish

one thread within running hours

You, flowing through selves

toward You.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Audre Lorde
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